

Extended spells of intense heat are likely to be the new normal

The **effects** of **global warming** on the Indian summer **have** been **evident** for at least a **decade**. The hot weather regularly **eats into** spring in most parts of the country, and heat waves are no longer restricted to regions traditionally believed to be **prone to** high temperatures — northern, central and eastern India. The Konkan region and parts of Karnataka, **for instance**, experienced **inordinately** high temperatures as early as February. Now, for the second **consecutive** year, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast above-normal temperatures for most parts of the country from April to June. It has warned of extended heat wave **episodes** that may **last** more than 10 days. Earlier, such episodes would last for four to seven days. However, last year, spells of intense heat **stretched** for over two weeks in several parts of the country.

The health effect of heat waves is a **nascent** field and data on **mortality** caused by them **varies** — the IMD, National Disaster Management Agency, Integrated Disease Surveillance Programme and National Crime Records Bureau **cite divergent** figures. However, experts **concur** on the need to put **in place** measures to protect **the most vulnerable**. Most states have prepared heat action plans. However, **by and large**, these plans **approach** the problem from an emergency **standpoint** — they focus on providing access to drinking water, creating shelters or changing work schedules. The **need** — as **underlined** by a study by researchers from Sustainable Futures Collaborative (SFC), a New Delhi-based research **outfit**, and scientists at King's College, London, and Princeton, Harvard and California universities — **is** to “make cooling available to the most heat-exposed, developing insurance cover for lost work, expanding fire management services and **retrofitting electricity grids**”.

There is near-**unanimity** on the need to **account for** local conditions while issuing heat wave alerts. Two years ago, for instance, a **sunstroke tragedy** in Navi Mumbai **underscored** the need to **factor in** humidity while evaluating the stress caused by **scorching** temperatures. **Devoting** special attention to **urban heat islands** **is** another **imperative** that cannot be delayed. These **enclaves** record much higher temperatures than the rest of the city because the heat does not have **outlets** to escape. The average March temperatures in the densely built Mumbai **suburbs** of Vasai and Ghatkopar, for instance, exceeded that of relatively greener Powai by as much as 13 degrees Celsius. **In the long run**, planners will need to find ways to reduce heat-retaining infrastructure and create more green spaces. Extended **spells** of intense heat **are** likely to be the new normal. The IMD's alert should **push policymakers** towards heat-proofing cities and towns. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Spell** (noun) – Period, Phase, Bout, Interval, Stretch अवधि
2. **Intense** (adjective) – Extreme, Severe, Fierce, Powerful, Strong तीव्र
3. **The new normal** (noun) – a previously unfamiliar or atypical situation that has become standard, usual, or expected. नया सामान्य
4. **Global warming** (noun) – the increase in the temperature of the earth's atmosphere, caused by the increase of certain gases वैश्विक तापमान वृद्धि
5. **Evident** (adjective) – Obvious, Clear, Apparent, Visible, Manifest स्पष्ट
6. **Decade** (noun) – Period of Ten years, दशक
7. **Eat into** (phrasal verb) – Encroach upon, Reduce, Diminish, Erode, Consume घटाना/कम करना
8. **Prone** (to) – (adjective) – Susceptible, Vulnerable, Liable, Inclined, Predisposed अतिसंवेदनशील
9. **For instance** (phrase) – For example, Such as, Like, Namely उदाहरण के लिए
10. **Inordinately** (adverb) – Excessively, Extremely, Unusually, Abnormally, Unduly अत्यधिक
11. **Consecutive** (adjective) – Successive, Continuous, Sequential, Uninterrupted, Straight लगातार
12. **Episode** (noun) – Occurrence, Incident, Event, Outbreak, Phase घटना
13. **Last** (verb) – Continue, Endure, Persist, Remain, Go on टिकना
14. **Stretch** (verb) – Extend, Prolong, Lengthen, Continue, Spread फैलना
15. **Nascent** (adjective) – Emerging, Developing, Budding, Incipient, Formative उभरता हुआ
16. **Mortality** (noun) – Death rate, Fatality, Lethality, Loss of life मृत्यु दर
17. **Vary** (verb) – Differ, Fluctuate, Change, Alternate, Diverge भिन्न होना
18. **Cite** (verb) – Quote, Reference, Mention, Name, Specify हवाला देना
19. **Divergent** (adjective) – Different, Conflicting, Discrepant, Disparate, Contrary भिन्न
20. **Concur** (on) – (verb) – Agree, Accord, Harmonize, Consent, Assent सहमत होना
21. **In place** (phrase) – Established, Ready, Set up, Organized, Arranged स्थापित

22. **The most vulnerable** (noun) – Atrisk groups, Disadvantaged, Defenseless, Susceptible सर्वाधिक असुरक्षित
23. **By and large** (phrase) – Generally, Mostly, Overall, Mainly, Predominantly सामान्य तौर पर
24. **Approach** (verb) – Handle, Address, Tackle, Manage, Deal with निपटना
25. **Standpoint** (noun) – Perspective, Viewpoint, Position, Angle, Outlook दृष्टिकोण
26. **Underline** (verb) – Emphasize, Highlight, Stress, Accentuate, Underscore जोर देना
27. **Outfit** (noun) – Organization, Institution, Group, Agency, Establishment संस्था
28. **Retrofit** (verb) – Upgrade, Modernize, Renovate, Improve, Adapt आधुनिकीकरण करना
29. **Electricity grid** (noun) – Power network, Electrical system, Utility grid, Power distribution system विद्युत ग्रिड
30. **Unanimity** (noun) – Agreement, Consensus, Harmony, Accord, Unity एकमत
31. **Account for** (phrasal verb) – Explain, Justify, Comprise, Represent, Constitute के लिये उत्तरदायी होना
32. **Sunstroke** (noun) – Heatstroke, Thermic fever, Heat exhaustion, Hyperthermia लू लगना
33. **Underscore** (verb) – Emphasize, Highlight, Stress, Accentuate, Underline जोर देना
34. **Factor in** (phrasal verb) – Consider, Include, Incorporate, Take into account, Allow for ध्यान में रखना
35. **Scorching** (adjective) – Blistering, Searing, Sweltering, Burning, Torrid झुलसाने वाला
36. **Urban heat island** (noun) – a phenomenon where cities experience significantly warmer temperatures than their surrounding rural areas due to the built environment absorbing and retaining heat more effectively than natural surfaces
37. **Imperative** (noun) – Necessity, Essential, Requirement, Obligation, Duty अनिवार्यता
38. **Enclave** (noun) – Zone, Area, Pocket, District, Sector क्षेत्र
39. **Outlet** (noun) – Vent, Escape, Release, Channel, Means निकास
40. **Suburb** (noun) – Outskirts, Peripheral area, Residential area, Commuter belt उपनगर
41. **In the long run** (phrase) – Eventually, Ultimately, In time, Over time, Finally लंबे समय में

42. **Push** (verb) – Urge, Encourage, Press,
Promote, Advocate प्रोत्साहित करना

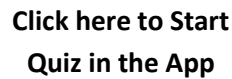
43. **Policymaker** (noun) – Decision-maker,
Legislator, Administrator, Government
official नीति निर्माता

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Summary of the Editorial

1. **Climate Change Impact:** Global warming has made Indian summers hotter, with heat waves starting earlier and lasting longer.
2. **Shifting Weather Patterns:** Heat waves now affect non-traditional regions like Konkan and Karnataka, not just North, Central, and East India.
3. **IMD Warning:** The India Meteorological Department predicts above-normal temperatures from April to June, with heat waves lasting over 10 days (previously 4-7 days).
4. **Record Heat Durations:** Last year, some regions endured extreme heat for over two weeks.
5. **Health Risks Understudied:** Heat-related mortality data is inconsistent across agencies (IMD, NDMA, NCRB), but experts agree on the need for protective measures.
6. **Inadequate State Plans:** Most heat action plans focus on emergency responses (water, shelters, adjusted work hours) rather than long-term solutions.
7. **Holistic Cooling Needed:** Research (SFC, King's College, Princeton, Harvard) suggests expanding cooling access, heat insurance, fire management, and grid resilience.
8. **Localized Heat Alerts:** Humidity and microclimates must be considered—Navi Mumbai's sunstroke deaths highlight this gap.
9. **Urban Heat Islands:** Dense cities like Mumbai have areas (Vasai, Ghatkopar) 13°C hotter than greener zones (Powai).
10. **Infrastructure Changes Needed:** Reducing heat-trapping structures (concrete, asphalt) and increasing green spaces are critical.
11. **Policy Delay Risks:** Without action, heat-related deaths, power outages, and productivity losses will rise.
12. **Vulnerable Populations:** Daily wage workers, the elderly, and outdoor laborers need targeted protections.
13. **Economic Costs:** Lost work hours and health burdens require insurance and compensation mechanisms.
14. **Long-Term Adaptation:** Cities must adopt heat-resilient urban planning (shaded walkways, reflective surfaces, water bodies).
15. **IMD's Call to Action:** The forecast should push policymakers to prioritize heat-proofing infrastructure and public health strategies.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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